

How does Duong Thu Huong use Juxtaposition to Emphasize Hang's Conflict Between
Tradition and Modernity in *Paradise of the Blind*?

Higher Level Essay

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Banned in Vietnam for possessing unconventional political views, *Paradise of the Blind* criticizes the inability for traditional values to coexist with contemporary values in the ever-changing world. Through the use of juxtaposition, Duong Thu Huong is able to emphasize a young girl, Hang's, conflicting perspectives through contrasting rural and urban settings, familial duty and personal freedom, and the character foils within her family. These illustrate both Duong and Hang's struggle to reconcile respect for their Vietnamese heritage with a strong desire for independence.

The novel begins in a small textile factory, where Hang is working as an exported worker and receives a telegram from her Uncle living in urban Moscow asking for her to visit and help him. To Hang, "[the] telegram felt like a curse", as she was sick and short on money herself (Duong, 12). Hang considers "preparing to abandon him", but then decides that "he's [her] uncle", so "[she doesn't] have the choice" (15). She considers leaving him again on the train, but decides "Too late, I thought. It's fate: I'll have to see him one last time after all" (203). Duong uses the juxtaposition between free will and filial piety to exaggerate tensions. Hang's free will tells her to rebel, but adherence to traditional familial obligations results in her helping her Uncle despite the oppressive treatment she received from him as a child. This is again implied when a Vietnamese student tells Hang that studying is "[their] only way out. And there's the duty to the family [to study]" (218), suggesting that time cannot change traditional values. Hang is still constrained by her traditional Vietnamese culture and identity which tell her to prioritize traditional familial obligations and follow her fate over her ability to choose independence.

The juxtaposition between urban and rural settings reflects the disparity between modern and traditional lifestyles. The rural village, where Aunt Tam resides, represents the suffocating grip of traditional customs and family obligations that suppress Hang's freedom. In contrast, the

urban cities of Hanoi and Moscow symbolize evolving modernity. Hang's memories, narrated during her train ride to Moscow, oscillate between the village and Hanoi, reflecting her internal conflict. Though she feels nostalgia for the village—"I had left the village, my aunt, and everyone there with a certain nostalgia"—this sentiment fades as she acknowledges the limitations of its traditions: "the ancestral home held nothing but bitter memories" (40, 172). Hang describes Moscow as "such a peaceful city, so different from Hanoi's savage screech of traffic", yet finds that "there was something sinister about this tranquility, and order of this existence" (202). The author's diction, using extreme words such as "savage", "bitter", and "sinister" to describe the modern cities, emphasizes the trap in which Hang is caught. As much as rural and urban settings contrast, they are ultimately similar for Hang because neither can offer her the choice to determine her life. Traditional rural settings give her no room for autonomy because tradition revolves around a set structure, with no room for personal freedom. Modernizing settings, Hang comes to realize, only provide the illusion of opportunity, but are also structured so that one is forced to follow a certain "order", thus suppressing individual desire (202).

Duong's careful choice of character relations effectively illustrates the duality that Hang faces continuously throughout her life. Aunt Tam and Uncle Chinh come from two sides of her family, and symbolize tradition and modernity respectively. The character foil between Uncle Chinh's "condescending" nature and Aunt Tam's sacrificial traditional one suggests their inability to coexist in Hang's life (22). Since Hang was just a child, Chinh's goal was to "crush the landowning classes, these cruel oppressors," referring to Aunt Tam (23). Uncle Chinh was "regarded as deeply learned... dispensers of enlightenment", which leads to him perceiving himself as capable and righteous, but the results of his "reforms" as a communist cadre are not

ideal (48). Even in the end, Uncle Chinh's character is described as "their own tragedy", trying to "re-create heaven on earth" without the intelligence to do it (225). The communist modernity that he believed in did not improve his life, but rather drew him into an ideology that only brought him fear. In contrast, Aunt Tam comes from a family that "has always lived in peace with everyone"(23). She does her best to hold onto the remains of a past life, but "her legacy to [Hang]...was a life deprived of youth and love, a victory born of the renunciation of existence" (248). Though she leaves a lot of material wealth for Hang, Hang does not feel content because along with this legacy, she must also embrace sacred traditional values that she hopes to leave behind. The portrayal of such contrasting characters as people who are equally important on two sides of Hang's family allows the reader to understand the tension Hang faces between respect for her cultural roots while yearning for the modern ideals of personal choice and freedom.

Duong incorporates another juxtaposition between youthful innocence and maturity, which shows her deviation off the path set up for her and her reluctance to comply with both traditional and modern ways of living. Hang's memories of her childhood act as a backdrop for the oppressive expectations placed on her. In the village where Hang grew up, "the cripple" sings: "Hail autumn and its procession of dead leaves." As a child, Hang appreciates the beauty of this song, but when she leaves for Moscow and then returns to Vietnam at the end of the novel, she interprets the song differently. Now, it represents a "life snuffed out" (235). She laments that her situation is similar to that of the cripple, who might want to be independent but is unable to escape the current situation. Hang finally comes to see the world for what it really is, and not the "paradise" that she once believed. The seasons, particularly autumn and winter, reflect Hang's evolving understanding of her place in the world. Autumn, with its "unique, foreign kind of beauty" initially evokes beauty and nostalgia but later symbolizes decay and lost

potential (225-226). Duong described Russian autumn as “golden”, but loses its beauty when Hang realizes “perhaps [she] was only meant to admire its beauty once” (231). Winter, in contrast, is “bitter cold” starkly reveals the hole in the roof that has always been neglected in Hang’s family, symbolizing the brutal reality Hang faces as she matures (226). Hang’s mother spends every little bit of money on her little brother, Hang’s Uncle Chinh, rather than focusing on the deeper issues in her own family. As the years pass, Chinh’s family fattens up whereas Hang starves and the hole in the roof is never repaired, further demonstrating the increasing attention that is given to Uncle Chinh and his modern communist ideology at the expense of people’s well-being. These seasonal juxtapositions deepen the narrative's exploration of Hang's disillusionment with both traditional and modern worlds.

The end of the text provides closure on both sides of Hang’s family, and truly frees her from her chains that had bound her for her entire life. On Uncle Chinh’s side, Hang is able to decide for herself that she will no longer help him, providing closure for herself and removing this feeling of guilt. The end of the text takes us out of Hang’s memory and back to her dormitory in Russia, where she yet again receives a telegram, this time informing her of Aunt Tam’s dying condition. Hang’s first impression of the village upon returning is one of acceptance that “nothing had changed” (239). The village is “[her] corner of the earth, [her] own paradise etched into the final evening of [her] childhood”, almost as if her ideal world ended the moment she realized tradition and modernity were incapable of coexisting (239). After Aunt Tam passes, Hang does everything for her “according to tradition”, however realizes that she “can’t squander [her] life tending these faded flowers, these shadows, the legacy of past crimes” (251, 258). Tradition and modernity were the very two factors that tore her family apart, so the only future Hang sees is one where she can leave this all behind and pursue her own future. Ultimately, her

choice to leave Aunt Tam's inherited legacy and pursue her own future in Russia shows her detachment from the traditional values that had once suppressed her identity.

In conclusion, *Paradise of the Blind* incorporates various forms of juxtaposition to illustrate the difficulty of finding a sense of belonging in an ever-changing contemporary world. Through Hang, who is unwilling to let anyone down by making a choice between traditional and evolving values, we are able to see how this duality has shaped her life, allowing readers to understand the significance of real-world events, like the Vietnam War, which had torn apart many families. Duong's persistence in sharing an ideology that was not acceptable in her own country empowers readers to follow their heart in the face of conflict.

Word Count: 1496

Works Cited

- [1] Duong Thu Huong. *Paradise of the Blind*. 1988. New York, Perennial, 2002.